CHAPTER 5

State and Society up to 1000 CE

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✨ Try each question yourself first, then check the answer. 💡
answers are samples: write your own.

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The Big Questions

1 How did society and state organise themselves prior to 1000 CE?

✔ ANSWER

- Society was built on families (kula), villages (grāma), viśha and jana, and was regulated mainly by customs.
- Social roles followed varṇa and, later, jāti; life was planned in four āśhramas and four puruṣhārthas.
- The state grew from clan chiefs (rājā) with assemblies to janapadas, mahājanapadas and empires (Mauryas, Guptas, Cholas).
- Empires were run by the king, a council of ministers and officers, through provinces, districts and self-reliant villages.

2 How did states and societies emerge and spread to different parts of the Indian subcontinent?

✔ ANSWER

- Early Vedic janas lived in the Sapta-Sindhu region; later the Ganga plains became the main centre.
- Iron tools, more crops (especially paddy) and growing trade made bigger territorial units possible.

- Between about 1000 BCE and 600 BCE janas became janapadas; from about 600 BCE, sixteen mahājanapadas arose and Magadha grew into the Mauryan Empire.
- In the south, the Satavāhanas, Cholas, Pandyas, Cheras and later Pallavas, Chālukyas and imperial Cholas formed states.

3 **How did the ideas of dharma and chakravarti samrāṭ help create unity in social values and governance, and promote the idea of the Indian subcontinent as one political entity?**

✔ ANSWER

- Dharma (duty, righteousness, moral conduct) gave everyone, including the king, common ethical rules: protect people, give justice, work for the welfare of all.
- The chakravarti samrāṭ was the ideal ruler of the whole land "between the Himavat and the sea" (chakravarti kśhetra).
- Terms like Jambudvīpa, Bhāratavarṣha and rituals like the aśhvamedha and rājasūya showed that rulers thought of the whole subcontinent as one domain.
- Rulers from Aśhoka to the Chera Nedunjeral Adan and Rajendra I Chola expressed this ideal.

4 **How did different social, administrative, and occupational groups take shape over time and come together culturally?**

✔ ANSWER

- The four varṇas began as flexible, occupation-based roles; later many jātis formed through intermarriage, endogamous migrating groups and regional differences.
- There was social and occupational mobility (e.g. silk weavers' guild of Mandsaur, brāhmaṇas as land managers).
- Guilds (śhreṇīs) united people of the same craft; village assemblies and committees (variyams) ran local affairs.
- Shared ideas (dharma, āśhramas, puruṣhārthas), Bhakti, education and trade routes linked these groups culturally.

⭐ Let's Explore · Timeline of the chapter

1–3 **Follow the timeline at the bottom of each page. Share one event you would like to explore further and document:**

1. What happened?

2. When did it happen?

3. Why do you think it matters?

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Model answer (event: foundation of Nalanda university):

1. **What happened?** Nalanda university was established.

2. **When?** 427 CE.

3. **Why it matters:** It became a famous centre of higher learning that attracted students from India and other regions, showing India's long tradition of education.

⭐ Let's Recall · Political Institutions in the Vedic Period

? The name 'Bharata' first appears in the Ṛigveda, for the 'Bharata jana', the people ruled by the family of the Bharatas. What does this tell us about how early communities identified themselves and their rulers?

✔ ANSWER

- Early communities identified themselves as a jana (clan) bound by kinship.
- The people were named after their ruling family, so the rājā was seen as the clan chief and the people and ruler shared one identity.

🤔 Think About It · Assemblies during the Vedic Period

? Do the roles of the rājā and the assemblies in Vedic times suggest a principle similar to modern democracies, where leaders are bound by constitutions and parliaments? Can we say that systems of governance in Indian

history were guided by the idea of ensuring people's participation?

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- Yes, to some extent. The rājā led in war and protection, but the sabhā (judicial body of elites), samiti (larger assembly on policy, representing the broader population) and vidhata (popular gathering) took part in decisions.
- Like a parliament today, the samiti represented people and could check the ruler.
- Later too, references to kings being elected or expelled, councils of ministers and village assemblies show that people's participation was valued.
- But these were not full democracies: some bodies had only select elites.

⭐ Let's Analyse · Iron finds of the first millennium BCE

? **More settlements are found in the Ganga region in the first millennium BCE, with iron implements, more grain, PGW and NBPW pottery. Can you identify the crucial factors behind this change?**

✔ ANSWER

- Use of **iron implements** (for clearing land and farming).

- **Expanding agriculture**: higher grain output and more crop variety, especially **paddy**, in the fertile Ganga plains.
- A richer material culture (PGW, then deluxe NBPW pottery), showing more prosperity and crafts.
- These made larger settlements and bigger political units possible.

🤔 Think About It · Duties and Ideals of the King

? Texts such as the Mahābhārata and the Arthaśhāstra describe the king's duties as protecting people and ensuring justice. Why was this important? What do these descriptions tell us about governance and the ruler–subject relationship?

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- Without protection from external threats and internal disorder, and without fair justice, people could not live and work in peace; society would fall into chaos.
- It shows the king was not meant to rule for himself: his power came with duties.
- The relationship was one of care and trust—the ruler had to judge strong and weak fairly and do good to the people, and the people supported the ruler.

- Kings could even be expelled, so authority was not absolute.

🤔 Think About It · Junagadh Rock Inscription

? Why do you think different rulers chose to record their inscriptions on the same stone instead of a new one? Discuss with your classmates.

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- The rock near Girnar was already a famous, respected public place that many people visited.
- Later rulers (Rudradaman I, Skandagupta) could link themselves to the great Mauryan emperor Aśhoka and show continuity.
- Their records were about the same Sudarshana Lake, so writing them at the same place made sense.
- A large, lasting rock surface was easy to use and kept the records safe for a long time.

🤔 Think About It · How Were Empires Administered?

? **How would dividing a kingdom into provinces, districts, and villages have helped rulers manage their empires? What similarities can you identify with the system of governance in India today?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- Smaller units are easier to manage: officers at each level could collect revenue, keep law and order and settle disputes close to the people.
- The king did not have to control every place himself; local officers and village assemblies knew local needs.
- **Today:** India is divided into states, districts, tehsils/blocks and villages (gram panchayats). Like district governors (pradeśhikas) we have District Collectors; like village assemblies we have gram sabhas and panchayats.

⭐ Let's Explore · Varṇa and Jāti (Ṛigveda 9.112.3)

1 **What occupations are mentioned in the family described in the verse? What does this indicate about the nature of occupations in Vedic society?**

✔ ANSWER

- **Poet** (the speaker), **physician** (father) and **grinder of corn** (mother).
- Members of one family did different jobs, so occupations were **flexible and mobile**, not fixed or hereditary.

2 **How does the above verse challenge the idea that social status and occupation were fixed by birth?**

✔ ANSWER

- If jobs were fixed by birth, the son would do his father's work. Here the son is a poet while the father is a physician and the mother grinds corn.
- So occupation (and status linked to it) depended on choice and ability, not only birth.

3 **What different occupations do you find in contemporary society?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Teachers, doctors, nurses, farmers, engineers, shopkeepers, drivers, software developers, police officers, artists, electricians, tailors, etc. Today people choose jobs by education and interest, and family members often do different work.

? **Did all groups interpret the source in the same way? What does this tell us about how historians use evidence?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- Groups may notice different clues and reach slightly different interpretations.
- Historians must read sources carefully, separate evidence from interpretation, know a source's limits (one verse does not describe all of society), and compare many sources before concluding.

⭐ Let's Explore · The Quest for Knowledge

? **Compare your school life with the life of a student in a gurukula (daily routine, subjects, relationship with teachers, discipline, living arrangements). What advantages and challenges might each system have?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Aspect	Gurukula	My school
Living	Lived in the teacher's home as a family member	Live at home, go to school daily
Subjects	Vedas, grammar, logic, philosophy, ethics, maths, science, medicine, astronomy, arts, archery, yoga	Languages, maths, science, social science, computers, sports, arts

Teacher	Guru as guide, very close relationship	Many teachers, more formal relationship
Discipline	Strict: self-control, obedience, service to the guru	Rules and timetable, less strict

- **Gurukula advantages:** personal attention, moral values, all-round education. **Challenges:** away from family, very strict, few students could attend.
- **School advantages:** many subjects, exams and certificates, open to all, live with family. **Challenges:** large classes, less personal attention, focus on marks.

🤔 Think About It · Irrigation

? Why do you think irrigational structures like dams and canals were considered so important that their construction was recorded in inscriptions?

✔ ANSWER

- Agriculture, the backbone of the economy, depended on irrigation.
- More crops meant more land revenue for the state, so facilitating agriculture was a major concern of rulers.

- Building or repairing them (e.g. the Sudarshana Lake dam by Puṣhyagupta) was a big public welfare work; recording it showed the ruler's care for people and kept the memory for future rulers.

? Questions and activities

1 **How did political organisation change from the Vedic period to the age of large empires such as the Mauryas and the Guptas?**

Explain the administrative system of the early Indian states.

✔ ANSWER

Change:

- Early Vedic period: kin-based janas led by a rājā (clan chief), with assemblies—sabhā, samiti, vidhata.
- About 1000–600 BCE: janas became territorial **janapadas**; control of land, farming and trade grew important.
- From about 600 BCE: sixteen **mahājanapadas**, both monarchies (rājyas) and republics (gaṇas/saṁghas); Magadha became most powerful.
- Then empires: Mauryas (from 321 BCE) and Guptas (320–550 CE).

Administration:

- King at the top, advised by a council of ministers (mantri-pariṣhad).

- Kingdom divided into provinces, divisions, districts and villages (e.g. bhukti, viṣhaya, adhiṣhṭhāna, vithi in the north; manḍalam, koṭṭam/valanāḍu, nāḍu in the south).
- Provincial governors, district officers (pradeśhikas) and city governors; village headman (grāmika) and self-reliant village assemblies.

2 **Describe the role of the king, important officers, and the methods used to govern large territories.**

✔ ANSWER

- **King:** protect subjects from external threats and internal disorder, give justice to strong and weak impartially, do good to the people.
- **Officers:** council of ministers—treasurer, chief tax collector, chief legal advisor, commander-in-chief; mantri (head of civil administration); Guptas added the sāndhivigrahika (minister of peace and war) and kumārāmātyas; district governors (pradeśhikas); city governors.

- **Methods:** division into provinces, districts and villages; consultation with bankers, caravan leaders, artisans and scribes (e.g. 5-member district office in the Damodarpur copper plates); self-governing village assemblies with committees (variyams); land revenue (generally one-sixth of produce); land grants (Brahmadeya, agrahārams).

3 **After studying this chapter, what do you think were the most important features of the state and society in India before 1000 CE?**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

- Growth from clans to kingdoms and large empires, with a well-organised, decentralised administration and strong village self-government.
- Ideas of dharma and ethical rule; the ideal of a ruler of the whole subcontinent.
- Society based on family, varṇa and jāti, with social mobility; āśhramas and puruṣhārthas.
- Respected roles of women in many periods; rich education (gurukulas, universities like Nalanda).
- Agriculture with irrigation, wide trade routes, ports and guilds.
- Remarkable continuity of traditions.

4 **What do early texts such as the Ṛigveda, Arthaśhāstra, and the Mahābhārata reveal**

about political and social life?

✔ ANSWER

- **Ṛigveda:** clans (janas) such as the pañchajana; rājā as clan chief; assemblies (sabhā, samiti, vidhata); flexible occupations within one family; first mention of four varṇas (Puruṣhasūkta); hymns by women sages.
- **Arthaśhāstra:** the king must be active; seven constituents of the state (Saptāṁga); council of ministers; types of land and revenue; trade of Magadha; prithivi = land between the Himalayas and the sea.
- **Mahābhārata (Śhānti Parva):** king's ethical conduct, justice and duty to protect subjects; punishments for crimes; principle of samatva; dharma as that which upholds all beings.

5 **What can we learn from early Indian society about varṇa and the role of women?**

✔ ANSWER

Varṇa:

- Four groups—brāhmaṇas, kṣhatriyas, vaiśhyas, śhūdras—each with roles; at first flexible and based on function and deeds, not birth (Sutta Nipāta). Flexibility reduced over time.

Women:

- In the Vedic period they took part in learning, rituals, chariot races and the sabhā; women sages such as Apālā, Ghoṣhā, Lopāmudrā.
- Their position fluctuated and even declined later, but women still worked in farming, crafts and religion; Prabhāvatī Gupta ruled as regent; Sangam poetesses Avvaiyar; Sembiyan Mahādevī supported temples.

6 **Explain how assemblies like sabhā and samiti limited the power of the rājā. Which modern institutions perform similar functions today?**

✔ ANSWER

- The **sabhā** (a smaller body of select elites) did judicial work, so justice was not only in the rājā's hands.
- The **samiti** (a larger assembly representing the broader population) discussed policy and political affairs, so the rājā had to consider people's views.
- The **vidhata** was a popular gathering to discuss war and politics.
- **Today:** Parliament (Lok Sabha, Rajya Sabha) and State Legislatures check the government; courts do judicial work; gram sabhas and panchayats in villages.

7 **What do the terms varṇa and jāti refer to in early Indian society?**

How were they different, and what factors may have contributed to the formation of various jātis?

✔ ANSWER

- **Varṇa:** the four social categories (brāhmaṇas, kṣhatriyas, vaiśhyas, śhūdras) linked to roles and tasks.
- **Jāti:** a later social structure of many groups, often linked to occupation and region.
- **Difference:** varṇas were fixed at **four**; there was **no limit** on jātis, which kept growing as new groups and occupations developed.
- **Factors:** intermarriage among varṇas, migrating communities becoming endogamous (marrying within the group), and territorial differences.

8 **Why do you think education in early India emphasised both knowledge and moral values? How might this have benefited society?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- Education was a complete preparation for life, not just a career. Good character and moral conduct were seen as the foundation of society.
- Students learnt values like truth, patience, humility, self-control and reverence for all beings, along with subjects and skills.

- **Benefit:** it produced skilled and honest people who did their duties to parents, teachers and society, bringing harmony and trust.

9 **Look at the major trade routes of early India (Fig 5.12). How do you think these routes helped people in the exchange of goods, skills, beliefs, and cultural practices?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- Dakṣhiṇāpatha and Uttarāpatha linked north, central and south India and connected inland cities with coastal ports (e.g. Muziris, Kāveripaṭṭinam, Arikameḍu, Masulipaṭnam).
- **Goods:** textiles, gems, pearls, metals, salt moved across regions and abroad (e.g. Rome).
- **Skills:** artisans and guilds travelled (e.g. silk weavers moved from Lata to Dashapura).
- **Beliefs and culture:** traders, monks and students carried ideas, languages, religions and art, linking the subcontinent culturally.

10 **What might have been the advantages and challenges of ruling a large empire in the absence of modern communication systems?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Advantages:

- Large land gave more revenue, resources, trade and military strength.
- Because orders were slow, power was shared: local officers and self-reliant village assemblies solved problems on the spot.

Challenges:

- Messages and orders took a long time; the king could not quickly know about revolts or disasters.
- Hard to control distant governors and to move armies; local officers could become too powerful.

11 **Many ideas about governance come from texts composed by scholars and advisors of the king. What might be some limitations of relying only on such sources?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- They may show how things **should** be (ideals), not how they really worked.
- They mostly give the view of rulers and elites, not common people, women or workers.
- They may praise the king or be biased; dates and places may be unclear.
- So historians also use inscriptions, archaeology, coins and other literature to check them.

12 (a) **Source: Nāśhik cave inscription (2nd century CE) of Uṣhavadāta—he gave a cave to the Saṁgha and a perpetual endowment of 3000 kāhāpaṇas, invested in guilds at Govadhana: 2000 in a weavers' guild (interest one pratika monthly per hundred) and 1000 in another weavers' guild (three quarters of a paḍika monthly per hundred).**

a. What does this source tell us about the economic role of guilds?

✔ ANSWER

- Guilds were not only associations of craftspersons; they acted as **banks**, accepting deposits and paying a fixed rate of interest.
- The interest was used to support the monks (cloth money etc.), so guilds also acted as **financiers and trustees**.

12 (b) **Why were guilds trusted with money deposits?**

✔ ANSWER

- They were well-established, influential institutions with steady income from their trade.

- They had their own rules and guild courts that supervised members' conduct, so they were reliable and could securely invest funds and pay steady interest.

12 (c) **Identify the donor and the donees from the given source.**

✔ ANSWER

- **Donor:** Uṣhavadāta, son of Dinika and son-in-law of king Nahapāna.
- **Donees:** the Saṁgha—Buddhist monks of any sect and origin living in the cave.

13 **Mark and locate on the map of India: Pāṭaliputra, Nāśhik, Ujjayinī, Vikramśhila, Kānchipuram, Mathurā, Rājgṛiha.**

✔ ANSWER

Centre	Where to mark
Pāṭaliputra	Present-day Patna, Bihar, on the Ganga
Nāśhik	Maharashtra, on the Godavari
Ujjayinī	Ujjain, Madhya Pradesh
Vikramśhila	Near Bhagalpur, eastern Bihar
Kānchipuram	Tamil Nadu, near Chennai
Mathurā	Uttar Pradesh, on the Yamuna
Rājgṛiha	Rajgir, Bihar, south of Patna

Use Fig. 5.10 and Fig. 5.12 in your book to check the places.

14 **Prepare a short presentation or poster on one of the following: a. Life in the Vedic society b. Early education system (gurukula) c. Trade and guilds in early India d. Role of women in early Indian society**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Sample poster (c. Trade and guilds in early India):

- **Routes:** Uttarāpatha and Dakṣhiṇāpatha (by 6th century BCE) linking the subcontinent.
- **Ports:** Muziris, Kāveripaṭṭinam, Arikameḍu, Masulipaṭnam; trade with Rome.
- **Goods:** textiles (silk, cotton, wool, linen), gems, coral, pearls, metals, salt.
- **Guilds (śhreṇīs):** 18 types in Jātaka literature; controlled quality and prices; guild courts; worked as banks (Nāśhik inscription).
- **Art:** ivory workers' guild of Vidiśhā carved the Sanchi gateway.
- Add a map of trade routes and pictures of punch-marked coins.

🎉 **Chapter 5 done! Revise the answers once more tomorrow.**